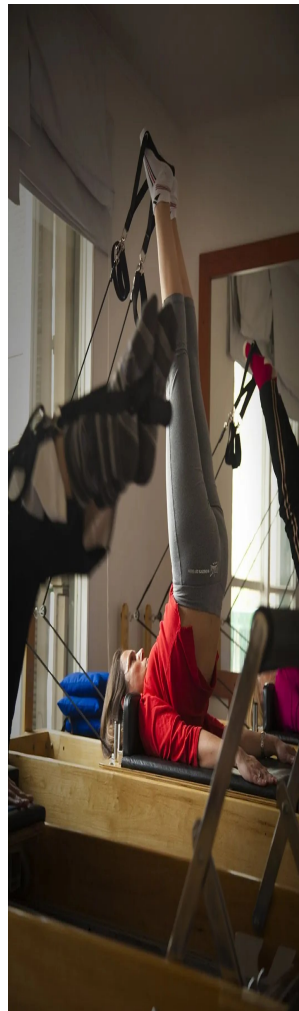


Strength Training on Biologics: Is It Safe?

Resistance work is not only safe — it's recommended.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Pending clinical review ·
2026-06-17 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Overview



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Resistance work is not only safe — it's recommended.

What the evidence shows

UK guidance from NICE, the British Society for Rheumatology and Arthritis UK consistently emphasises a combined approach: appropriate medication, regular movement, and supportive lifestyle changes. Recent reviews continue to back this consensus.

What this means for you



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- ****Talk to your clinician.**** Personalised advice always beats blanket rules.
- ****Track your symptoms.**** Use a simple diary so you can spot patterns over weeks, not days.
- ****Move within comfort.**** Gentle, regular activity protects joints and mood.

- ****Watch the warning signs.**** New swelling, fever, or rapid loss of function deserve same-week review.
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Practical next steps

1. Read our companion piece for a deeper dive: [\[related guidance\]\(/exercise-hub\)](#). 2. Bring three questions to your next GP or rheumatology appointment. 3. Share this article with a family member who supports you day to day.

Editorial standards



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This article was prepared by the Living With Arthritis Editorial Team from UK NICE guidance and peer-reviewed sources. Pending clinical review. We update

content at least annually.

What the Evidence Says

Current research strongly supports the benefits of strength training for people living with arthritis, even those taking biologics. Large-scale reviews of many studies consistently show that carefully planned resistance exercises can improve muscle strength, reduce pain, and boost overall physical function. This evidence comes from a mix of randomised trials and observational studies, which track people over time.

Clinical guidelines from professional bodies across the UK and internationally now routinely recommend strength training as a core part of managing arthritis. These recommendations highlight that, when supervised and adapted to individual needs, the benefits of exercise far outweigh any potential risks. The key is finding the right balance and intensity for each person.

The evidence also suggests that exercise, including strength training, can complement the effects of medications like biologics. While biologics work to reduce inflammation, exercise helps maintain joint mobility and muscle mass, addressing other aspects of living with a long-term condition. This combined approach often leads to better long-term outcomes and a higher quality of life.

Common Mistakes to Avoid

* **Starting too quickly:** Gradually increase weights or resistance over several weeks. * **Ignoring pain:** Distinguish between muscle fatigue and joint pain; avoid movements that cause sharp or lasting joint discomfort. * **Poor form:** Focus on correct technique over lifting heavy weights to protect your joints. * **Inconsistency:** Little and often is better than sporadic, intense sessions. * **Skipping warm-ups/cool-downs:** These are crucial for preparing your body and aiding recovery. * **Not asking for help:** A physiotherapist can provide a tailored exercise plan.

When to Speak to a Clinician

While strength training is generally beneficial, there are times when you should seek professional advice before continuing or starting a new routine. If you experience any new or worsening symptoms that concern you, it's always best to get them checked.

Consider speaking to your general practitioner, physiotherapist, or rheumatology specialist if you notice:

- * Sudden, unexplained joint swelling or increased warmth around a joint.
- * New, persistent pain that doesn't subside after activity or rest.
- * Fever, chills, or unusual fatigue alongside your exercise.
- * Significant increase in joint stiffness or loss of movement.
- * Any signs of infection, such as redness or pus, around your joints.

Frequently Asked Questions

Will strength training make my arthritis worse? No, when done correctly and tailored to your condition, strength training is highly unlikely to worsen your arthritis. In fact, it can protect your joints by strengthening the muscles around them, improving stability and reducing impact during daily activities. Listening to your body and working with a professional are key to a safe and effective programme.

How soon after starting biologics can I begin strength training? It's generally safe to continue or start strength training once your condition is stable and you're tolerating your biologic medication well. However, always discuss this with your rheumatologist or specialist nurse. They can advise based on your specific health situation and how your body is responding to treatment.

What if I have a flare-up while strength training? During an arthritis flare-up, it's wise to reduce the intensity and type of exercise. You might switch to gentler activities like walking or stretching, or rest the affected joints. Once the flare-up subsides, you can gradually return to your strength training routine. Always consult your clinician if you're unsure or if the flare-up is severe.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about strength training on biologics: is it safe??

Short answer: Strength training is generally safe and recommended for people with arthritis, even those on biologics. Research shows it can improve muscle strength, reduce pain, and boost physical function. It's crucial to start slowly, focus on proper form, and listen to your body, stopping if you experience new or lasting joint pain. Always discuss your exercise plan with your clinician.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Arthritis UK: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis · livingwitharthritis.org.uk